

■ By Swagata Sen

Fourteen years ago, he was the kind of student multinational companies would swoop down on in campus interviews. There was nothing in his background to even suggest that he wouldn't oblige them after his degree. Armed with a B.Tech from IIT Kharagpur, and pursuing a Ph.D in sustainable energy from the University

of Massachusetts, USA, H. Harish Hande hailed from the pampered environs of the Rourkela Steel Plant, where his father worked as a senior officer.

Only, while writing his Ph.D, Hande realised that he had never had any first-hand experience of what it might be to live without electricity. He decided to come back to India, and live in the villages in Karnataka (his state of origin) and Sri Lanka. After two years of living without electricity, he knew what he wanted to do with his life. He wanted to provide solar power to those who had never seen bulbs light up in their homes. Today, his company, Selco Solar Lights, has provided customised solar lighting solutions to about 95,000 households in the villages of Karnataka and Gujarat, and he now hopes to reach twice the number of households by 2011.

Hande calls his company an experiment that aims at breaking the myth that sustainable energy is expensive and therefore only for the rich. He operates his company on a zero-subsidy basis—if his clients, who mostly belong to the below the poverty

line group, want to light up their homes they have to pay for it. Around 44 per cent of Karnataka's population doesn't have access to conventional electricity. But what Selco does here is more than just providing solar panels. If a man has three rooms but can afford light only in one, the technicians of the company will make a hole near the ceiling and place the light in such a way that all three rooms are lit perfectly. Selco has also convinced rural banks to provide loans for light connections. A single point connection costs Rs 5,000 and a four-point connection comes at Rs 18,000. These are just one-time costs. If, in a case, the customer is unable to pay his down payment, the company acts as a guarantor to the customer for a year while he repays the bank in instalments. Hande proudly talks of one of his customers, a woman who lives in a hut made of twigs but has a connection, and pays Rs 5 a day to the bank.

It wasn't really easy to convince his customers that electricity would change their lives. In 1994, an American acquaintance

let there BE LIGHT

✱ **H. Harish Hande, 40**

Project Selco, a company that provides customised solar lighting solutions

Can-do Icon Mahatma Gandhi, for he talked of decentralisation and self-sustenance, which fits into Selco's philosophy

Solar energy is 0.5 per cent of the total energy produced in India



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The solutions to poverty lie in sustainable energy. The NGO culture has completely spoiled the chances of self-reliance in our country.

H. HARISH HANDE, Founder, Selco

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